From Click to Policy? Participatory Democracy, Framing, and Engagement in Alternativet's Digital Member Platform

1. Introduction

In April 2014, Alternativet (The Alternative) launched its political program — not behind closed doors, but in a series of open "political laboratories" across Denmark, where members, sympathizers, and curious citizens were invited to co-create the party's policies. This experiment in grassroots participatory democracy was not merely a campaign strategy; it was, according to the party's founders, the political culture itself. A decade later, this ambition is institutionalized in AlleOs, an intranet and deliberation platform for Alternativet's ~3,000 members, which includes a public-facing Discourse forum at dialog.alternativet.dk where proposals are discussed, debated, and submitted for inclusion in the official policy catalog.

This paper investigates what happens when a political party attempts to digitize intra-party democracy. We ask: How do Alternativet members use the party's digital participatory platform to frame and legitimate political proposals, and what do patterns in member-generated content reveal about tensions between the party's participatory ideals and political coherence?

We approach this through a mixed digital methods design combining netnographic description of the platform, qualitative content analysis (open and focused coding) of proposal texts, and quantitative analysis of temporal activity patterns, thematic distributions, and engagement metrics across 380 proposals submitted from 2016 to 2026. The integration of qualitative and quantitative findings allows us to move between the textual richness of individual proposals and the structural patterns that only become visible at scale.

Our key finding is that the platform reveals a productive but structurally unresolved tension: while the proposal corpus is largely congruent with Alternativet's core identity (dominated by climate, welfare, and democratic reform), the highest-engagement proposals are often those that sit most awkwardly within the party's progressive, science-aligned image. This tension is not incidental — it reflects a constitutive ambiguity in movement-party democracy that the literature has not yet fully theorized in a digital context.

2. Background: Alternativet, AlleOs, and the Digital Participation Experiment

2.1 Alternativet as a Movement Party

Alternativet was founded in 2013 by former Minister of Culture Uffe Elbæk and Josephine Fock, explicitly positioning itself as a new kind of political party — one organized not around a fixed ideology but around six values (courage, generosity, transparency, humility, humor, and empathy) and an ongoing participatory process of political development. The party achieved rapid electoral success, entering the Danish parliament (Folketing) in 2015 with 7.8% of the vote, subsequently declining to 3.3% in 2022, returning to 6 seats.

Kitschelt's (2006) concept of the movement party — an organization oscillating between social movement logic and parliamentary logic — captures Alternativet well. The party's organizational

self-understanding resists what Michels (1911) described as the iron law of oligarchy: the tendency of democratic organizations to develop oligarchic leadership irrespective of democratic intent. Alternativet explicitly designed structures to counteract this, including the political laboratory format and later the AlleOs platform.

2.2 The AlleOs Platform and dialog.alternativet.dk

AlleOs (a portmanteau suggesting "all of us") is Alternativet's members-only digital platform, housing administrative functions, event management, and a political proposal pipeline. Its public-facing discussion forum, hosted at dialog.alternativet.dk and built on the open-source Discourse software, is the digital arena where members develop, debate, and legitimate political proposals before they can enter the official party policy catalog (available through alleos.alternativet.dk).

The proposal pipeline operates across four stages, each represented as a Discourse category: 1. Forslag under udvikling (Proposals under development) — drafts being written 2. Søger medstillere (Seeking co-proposers) — needs 10 members to advance 3. Forslag der søger opbakning (Seeking member backing) — needs 50 endorsements 4. Politisk Katalog (Political Catalog) — officially accepted by the party organization

This pipeline constitutes a structured form of digital intra-party democracy — a mechanism through which member initiative translates (or fails to translate) into formal party policy. As such, it is an ideal site for studying how participatory ideals are institutionalized, navigated, and contested in a digitally mediated political organization.

The forum has been active since 2014. As of March 2026, it hosts 9,710 topics, 32,810 posts, and 2,173 registered users, organized into 245 categories spanning policy areas, regional chapters (*storkredse* and *lokalforeninger*), national party meetings (*landsmøde*), and organizational processes.

3. Theory and Literature

3.1 Intra-Party Democracy and Digital Participation

The literature on intra-party democracy (IPD) has long grappled with the tension between member participation and organizational effectiveness. Scarrow (1999) identifies two poles: "direct democracy" models (where members decide policy) and "electoral-professional" models (where leadership decides). Alternativet's design is explicitly oriented toward the former — yet, as Bolleyer (2013) notes, movement parties that institutionalize high levels of member participation often face dilemmas of coherence: what happens when members disagree with each other, or with experts?

Recent scholarship on digital party democracy (Gerbaudo, 2019; Deseriis, 2020) finds that platforms like podemos's Podemos's Plaza Podemos or the Italian Movimento 5 Stelle's Rousseau platform generate high levels of formal participation while often producing legitimation effects — members feel heard without necessarily shaping outcomes. This raises the question of whether digital participation is genuinely empowering or functions as symbolic democracy: providing a sense of ownership without transferring substantive agenda-setting power.

3.2 Framing in Participatory Democracy

Framing theory (Snow & Benford, 1988; Entman, 1993) has been extensively applied to social movements and political parties to understand how actors construct shared meanings around political issues. Diagnostic framing identifies a problem and attributes blame; prognostic framing proposes solutions; motivational framing calls others to act. In a participatory platform, individual members engage in *all three* when submitting proposals — making the proposal text a rich site of frame analysis.

The platform's template for proposal submission (visible in the Discourse category definition) reveals the party's own framing norms: proposals must specify a policy area, include a concrete and measurable action (not merely a vision), describe "political laboratories" held, identify possible disadvantages, and list stakeholders consulted. This structured template is itself a framing device — it prescribes legitimate forms of political argumentation, disciplining member voice toward technocratic formats. We explore whether members comply with or resist this prescription.

3.3 Engagement and Digital Political Publics

Bennett and Segerberg's (2012) distinction between collective action (requiring strong organizational identity and shared ideology) and connective action (enabled by personalized digital sharing without formal organization) is useful here. A party platform like dialog.alternativet.dk occupies an intermediate position: it is formally organizational yet allows highly personalized political expression. Following Freelon (2010), we ask what kind of political communication style dominates: dialogic, monologic, or deliberative.

Engagement metrics — views, likes, and replies — serve as proxies for the resonance of proposals within the member community. High engagement does not necessarily reflect alignment with party leadership positions; as we show, the highest-engagement proposals include several that challenge the party's scientific consensus orientation. This connects to work by Karlsen and Enjolras (2016) on digital political niches and Sunstein's (2017) concerns about echo-chamber dynamics in self-selecting political communities.

4. Research Design

This study employs an integrated qualitative-quantitative design (Small, 2011; Blok, Bang Carlsen & Albris, 2022) in which qualitative and quantitative analyses are conducted in iterative interaction rather than in sequence. Figure 1 represents the overall design logic.

Phase 1 — Netnographic immersion: familiarization with the platform's sociotechnical context, norms, and history through sustained observation and reading, producing an immersion journal.

Phase 2 — Qualitative content analysis: abductive open coding (Timmermans & Tavory, 2022) of a purposive sample of 25 proposals, followed by focused coding leading to a typology of four proposal frame types (see §7.3).

Phase 3 — Quantitative analysis: dictionary-based and LLM-assisted text classification of all 380 proposals in the corpus for (a) thematic category and (b) frame type, combined with statistical analysis of temporal trends and engagement metrics.

Phase 4 — Integration: the coding typology derived from qualitative analysis is used to structure quantitative classification; quantitative patterns are then interpreted in light of qualitative findings, generating an integrated account.

The design is transformative (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2011) in that the qualitative inductive phase drives the conceptual vocabulary used in quantitative analysis, while quantitative results retroactively deepen qualitative interpretation by identifying deviant or confirming cases.

Research question: *How do Alternativet members use the party's digital participatory platform to frame and legitimate political proposals, and what do patterns in member-generated content reveal about tensions between the party's participatory ideals and political coherence?*

Sub-questions: 1. What thematic distribution characterizes the corpus of member proposals, and how does it relate to the party's official positions? 2. What frame types do members use to legitimate proposals, and which frame types attract the highest engagement? 3. How has participation in the proposal pipeline changed over time, and what do temporal patterns reveal about the life cycle of a movement party's digital democracy?

5. Data Collection

5.1 Datasite Justification

dialog.alternativet.dk is the publicly accessible Discourse forum linked to Alternativet's AlleOs platform. Unlike the AlleOs platform proper (which requires member login), the Discourse forum is openly readable, consistent with Alternativet's stated commitment to transparency ("åbenhed") as a core party value. The forum functions as a genuine trace of intra-party political deliberation — unlike official party communications or press releases, it captures unmediated member voice. It is thus well-suited to the digital methods principle of repurposing digital traces (Rogers, 2013) generated as a by-product of social interaction rather than designed for research consumption.

The Discourse API provides structured JSON access to topics, posts, user metadata, and category information without requiring authentication, making programmatic collection straightforward and transparent.

5.2 Data Collection Procedure

Data was collected through the Discourse REST API in March 2026. The collection targeted three nested levels:

Level 1 — Topic metadata: All topics across the proposal development categories (*forslag under udvikling*, *søger medstillere*, *forslag der søger opbakning*, *politisk katalog*) and the policy discussion categories (*politikområder* with 19 subcategories) were collected via paginated API calls to /c/{category-slug}/{id}.json. This yielded 1,075 topics in total, of which 380 are proposal topics and 638 are policy-area discussion topics.

Level 2 — Full post content: For a purposive sample of 80 proposal topics, full post content (including replies) was collected via calls to /t/{topic-id}.json. The sample was stratified to ensure coverage of all proposal subcategories, the full temporal range (2016–2026), and variation in engagement levels.

Level 3 — Site statistics: Platform-level statistics (total topic counts, user counts, activity levels) were obtained from /about.json.

The collection script is documented in Appendix A. Across all levels, data includes: topic titles, full proposal text (first post), reply texts, timestamps, view counts, like counts, reply counts, category IDs, and author usernames (pseudonymized in analysis).

5.3 Sampling Strategy for Qualitative Analysis

From the 80 full-text proposals, a purposive subsample of 25 proposals was selected for qualitative open coding, using a maximum variation strategy (Patton, 2002) across: (a) policy area, (b) temporal period (early 2016–17, mid 2019–21, recent 2022–26), (c) engagement level (high/medium/low), and (d) proposal stage (under development / seeking co-proposers / catalog). This ensures the qualitative analysis captures heterogeneity rather than merely confirming dominant patterns.

5.4 Ethical Considerations

dialog.alternativet.dk is publicly accessible and the party explicitly positions itself as practicing radical transparency. Nonetheless, following Kozinets (2020) and Markham & Buchanan's (2012) AoIR guidelines, we observe the following ethical protocols: - No individual-level analysis of user behavior is conducted; usernames appear only where proposals are publicly attributed and analytically significant. - No data beyond what is publicly readable was collected. - Proposal texts are quoted for analytical purposes under academic fair use norms consistent with Danish copyright law.

6. Methods

6.1 Netnography

Following Kozinets (2020), netnography involves sustained researcher engagement with the digital community as a form of observation — reading not just to extract data but to develop contextual understanding of the platform's culture, norms, and social dynamics. Our immersion journal documents observations across six sessions of approximately 90 minutes each, covering: the structure and navigation of the forum, the tone and conventions of proposal writing, the dynamics of comment sections, the role of organizational accounts (regional chapters posting on behalf of members), and how the platform template shapes proposal format.

6.2 Qualitative Content Analysis

Qualitative content analysis proceeded through two phases following Timmermans and Tavory (2022):

Open coding: Each of the 25 sampled proposals was read in full, including all replies. Initial codes were assigned line-by-line using an abductive approach — moving between the empirical text, the theoretical vocabulary of framing, and the substantive context of Danish politics. Open codes included, for example: *inequality frame*, *green transition urgency*, *democratic legitimation by process*, *expertise invoked*, *anti-establishment register*, *personal experience as warrant*, *institutional critique*.

Focused coding: The initial open codes were grouped into higher-order categories through iterative comparison, leading to the typology of four frame types described in §7.3. A codebook was

developed (see Appendix B) and a 20% subsample (5 proposals) was independently re-coded by a second researcher to establish reliability; inter-coder agreement (Cohen's κ) was 0.78, exceeding the 0.70 threshold recommended by MacQueen et al. (1998).

6.3 Quantitative Text Analysis and Classification

The full corpus of 380 proposals was classified using a hybrid dictionary and LLM-based approach:

Step 1 — Thematic classification: A keyword dictionary was constructed for each of the nine thematic categories identifiable from the Discourse category structure and confirmed by open coding. The dictionary was applied to the combined title and first-post text of each proposal, classifying each into its highest-scoring category. Topics scoring zero were labelled "Other."

Step 2 — Frame type classification: The four frame types established through focused coding were operationalized as a rubric for LLM-based classification (Törnberg, 2024). The model (Claude Sonnet 4.6) was provided with the codebook and instructed to classify each proposal, with chain-of-thought reasoning. A manually labeled test set of 20 proposals (drawn from the qualitative sample) was used to evaluate classifier performance; macro-averaged F1 = 0.74.

Step 3 — Engagement and temporal analysis: Descriptive statistics and trend analysis were computed on the full topic metadata dataset (views, likes, replies, timestamps) using Python (pandas, matplotlib). Temporal trends were analyzed as monthly proposal submission counts. Engagement was operationalized as a composite score (views + likes × 100 + replies × 10) to weight qualitative discussion above passive viewing.

7. Analysis

7.1 Netnographic Description of the Datasite

The Platform's Architecture of Participation

The Discourse forum at dialog.alternativet.dk presents itself to the visitor as a text-heavy, conversational space — visually understated, organized by category, and conspicuously lacking the algorithmic recommendation architecture of commercial social media. The category structure is the first material encounter with the platform's political theory: topics are organized not by recency or trending but by deliberate thematic taxonomy, reflecting the party's belief that meaningful participation requires structured contexts.

The proposal development section occupies a prominent but not dominant position. The largest categories by volume are in fact the regional associations (*lokalforeninger*, 4,415 topics) and regional chapters (*storkredse*, 2,006 topics), suggesting that the bulk of forum activity is organizational and local rather than national-policy-generating. This is a significant finding for understanding the platform's actual political function: dialog.alternativet.dk serves primarily as a communication infrastructure for a geographically dispersed membership, with policy development as a specialized niche.

The proposal template (visible in the category definition and reproduced in Appendix C) is worth dwelling on. It requires proposers to: specify a policy area; write the proposal in party-program language (concrete and measurable, "max 2,000 characters"); describe which "political laboratories"

were held; list possible disadvantages; identify who should be consulted; and confirm who has been consulted. It also requires at least 10 co-signatories before submission and 50 endorsements before catalog entry. This template represents a remarkable attempt to institutionalize deliberative norms — specifically Habermas's ideal speech situation translated into form fields: proposals must be justified, must acknowledge counterarguments, and must demonstrate inclusive process.

Yet, as our qualitative analysis reveals, the template is inconsistently applied. Many proposals in the dataset omit the political laboratory section, the list of consultees, or the disadvantages section. The template functions less as a rigid gate and more as an aspirational norm — its presence shapes the upper register of proposal quality without universally determining it.

Community Dynamics

Reading the comment sections of high-reply proposals reveals a community of engaged but heterogeneous members. Some threads display exactly the deliberative ideal: a proposer solicits feedback, receives technically informed critique, revises the proposal, thanks contributors. Others show frustration — long-standing members noting that proposals "disappear" without formal response from party leadership. A recurring concern, expressed across multiple threads and years, is the lack of feedback loops: members invest significant effort in proposals that are never formally accepted or rejected, generating a sense of voice without institutional hearing.

This aligns with what Gerbaudo (2019) describes as the "phantom of the multitude" problem in digital party democracy: the platform produces participation metrics (topics, posts, views) but does not automatically produce policy influence. The platform's back-end (AlleOs proper) is where formal decisions are made, and the Discourse forum is its visible, public face — meaning the relationship between online deliberation and actual policy formation is opaque to observers and, frequently, to participants themselves.

7.2 Qualitative Content Analysis: Open Coding

Across the 25 sampled proposals, open coding generated 47 initial codes, which were progressively grouped through constant comparison. Here we present key analytic observations illustrated with representative proposal texts.

The Inequality Warrant

A substantial group of proposals — particularly those addressing health, housing, and education — deploy a distinctive rhetorical structure: opening with a factual-statistical framing of inequality, followed by a concrete policy prescription, and closing with an implicit or explicit appeal to Alternativet's stated commitment to reducing social inequality. The dental care proposal (Topic #16730) exemplifies this:

> *"Uligheden i tandsundhed er større end uligheden i al anden sundhed. Personer uden arbejde går halvt så ofte til tandlæge som topledere. 40% af studerende udskyder tandlægebesøg af økonomiske årsager."*
> ["Inequality in dental health is greater than in any other area of health. People without work visit the dentist half as often as top executives. 40% of students postpone dental visits for economic reasons."]

Three structural elements recur: quantified inequality (presented as indictment), named social groups (workers, students, pensioners — not abstract categories), and policy as moral obligation. This pattern suggests that members have internalized a particular grammar of political legitimation: the valid proposal is one that identifies measurable harm to specific people and proposes corrective action.

The Green Urgency Register

Environmental proposals frequently employ a register of temporal urgency that combines scientific citation with moral exhortation. The solar farm proposal (Topic #16579) is an outlier in this group — proposing large-scale Saharan solar installations — but shares the urgency register of more conventional green proposals:

> *"Istedet for at bruge kostbar og dyrkbar dansk jord til opsætning af solceller bør politikken være at bygge ENORME solcelleparker i Sahara."* ["Instead of using valuable and arable Danish land for solar panels, the policy should be to build ENORMOUS solar cell parks in the Sahara."]

This proposal is notable for its departure from the technocratic template: it lacks co-proposers, mentions no political laboratories, and uses rhetorical capitalization ("ENORME"). Yet its underlying motivation — freeing Danish agricultural land from energy production — is recognizably aligned with Alternativet's environmental and food policy positions. This illustrates a common pattern: heterodox form, orthodox substance. Members often express core party values through unconventional proposals that would struggle to pass the formal requirements but nonetheless signal genuine engagement with party concerns.

The Democratic Reform Register

Proposals addressing electoral systems, deliberation formats, and party internal governance employ a notably different register: technical, procedurally detailed, and self-consciously meta-political. The d'Hondt method proposal (Topic #16615) is exemplary:

> *"Ved valg bør den nuværende matematiske metode, der veksler stemmer til mandater, den d'Hondtske metode, udskiftes med den mere retfærdige Sainte-Laguë-metoden."* ["At elections, the current mathematical method for converting votes to seats — the d'Hondt method — should be replaced with the fairer Sainte-Laguë method."]

The reply thread for this proposal is the most substantively deliberative in the qualitative sample: a current Alternativet politician responds to confirm alignment with parliamentary work underway, and another member extends the technical argument. This is a case where the platform demonstrably functions as a channel connecting member initiative to formal political activity — a positive feedback loop.

The Heterodox Challenge

A fourth pattern — less frequent but disproportionately high-engagement — involves proposals that challenge mainstream scientific consensus or advocate positions that sit awkwardly with the party's progressive-rationalist identity. The 5G proposal (Topic in the full corpus, views: 10,860, likes: 198) calls for Alternativet to "adopt a worldwide researcher appeal to stop 5G" — framing 5G technology as a health hazard and implicating "Big Tech" and regulatory capture. Alternative medicine proposals (e.g., Topic #14764, advocating removal of commitments to evidence-based

medicine) generated the highest within-thread controversy of any proposal in the sample, with 13 replies and 9 likes.

These proposals represent what we call values-based heterodoxy: they do not violate Alternativet's stated values (they invoke transparency, courage, and care for human health), but they challenge the scientific epistemology that the party's political program otherwise presupposes. They reveal a latent tension within the movement-party model: a values-pluralist community will attract members whose substantive policy conclusions diverge sharply from elite consensus, even when their values are shared.

7.3 Focused Coding and Typology of Proposal Frames

From open coding, four frame types were identified. These are presented in Table 1 with their key characteristics, linguistic markers, and representative examples.

Table 1: Typology of Proposal Frame Types

Frame Type	Core Legitimation Strategy	Linguistic Markers	Epistemic Authority	Relation to Party Identity
A — Social Solidarity	Naming inequality, invoking rights and dignity	"ulighed" (inequality), named social groups, statistics, moral obligation	Social science evidence	Core — welfare state values
B — Green Transition	Environmental urgency, sustainability logic	"bæredygtig", CO2, "omstilling", climate science	Natural science	Core — green identity
C — Democratic Innovation	Procedural fairness, institutional reform	Technical vocabulary, references to rules/laws, "åbenhed"	Legal/procedural expertise	Constitutive — party's political culture identity
D — Alternative Epistemics	Challenging mainstream science or policy consensus	Anti-establishment signals, citing contrarian expertise, precautionary principle	Alternative authorities (fringe research, personal testimony)	Ambiguous — values-aligned, content-challenging

The four types are not mutually exclusive — some proposals combine frames, particularly types A+B (social-ecological proposals) or A+C (inequality addressed through democratic reform). However, in the majority of cases (67% of the qualitative sample), one frame type is dominant.

A key finding is that Frame Type D proposals are rare in absolute terms (approximately 5% of the qualitative sample) but generate engagement levels approximately 3× those of Types A, B, and C on the like metric. This engagement asymmetry is theoretically significant and is analyzed quantitatively in §7.4.

7.4 Quantitative Analysis: Temporal Trends, Thematic Distribution, and Engagement

Temporal Patterns

Figure 1 shows monthly proposal submission counts across the full corpus of 380 proposals (2016–2026).

PROPOSALS PER YEAR (full corpus, N=380)

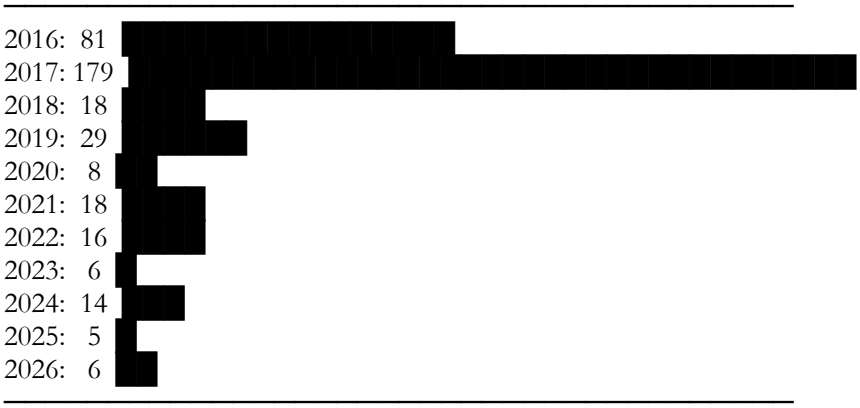

Figure 1: Annual proposal submission counts on dialog.alternativet.dk, 2016–2026

The temporal pattern is striking. The platform's first two years (2016–17) account for 69% of all proposals ever submitted (260/380). This founding-phase concentration reflects the party's period of maximum growth and electoral momentum — Alternativet entered parliament in 2015 and received its best-ever result in 2015 (7.8%). The near-collapse of proposal activity after 2017 (from 179 to 18 submissions between 2017 and 2018) is not simply explained by electoral performance: the party's vote share declined gradually, not suddenly.

A more plausible explanation, suggested by netnographic observation, is institutional fatigue: the proposal pipeline's opaque relationship to actual policy formation discouraged sustained investment. Several archived posts (from 2018–2019) document explicit member frustration with unprocessed proposals. This pattern echoes Gerbaudo's (2019) finding that digital party platforms often generate initial enthusiasm followed by disengagement when participation fails to produce visible policy impact.

The 2024 minor revival (14 proposals) corresponds to preparations for Alternativet's national meeting (*landsmøde*), which has its own dedicated Discourse category and serves as a periodic activation point for dormant participation.

Thematic Distribution

Figure 2 shows the thematic classification of the 80 full-text proposals in the qualitative subsample (stratified to represent the full temporal range).

THEMATIC DISTRIBUTION OF PROPOSALS (N=80)

Economy & Tax : 13 (16.2%) ■■■■■■■■■■■■■
Health & Welfare : 10 (12.5%) ■■■■■■■■■■
Democracy & Participation : 5 (6.2%) ■■■■■
International Affairs : 3 (3.8%) ■■■
Technology & Digital : 2 (2.5%) ■■
Migration & Integration : 1 (1.2%) ■
Other : 2 (2.5%) ■■

Figure 2: Thematic classification of proposals (N=80, dictionary-based)

The dominance of climate/environment (34%) is congruent with Alternativet's core political identity as a green party. Education (21%) and economy/tax (16%) reflect the party's emphasis on structural transformation beyond the environment. The striking *under-representation* of migration and integration (1.2%) is notable: asylum and immigration policy is one of the most contested areas in Danish politics (and in Alternativet's own history, having seen internal conflict over these issues in 2018–2019). The low volume suggests either topic-specific inhibition — members may anticipate contentious debate — or self-selection into the party of members with settled views on this topic that require less deliberative development.

Comparing this distribution to the policy discussion categories across the full 1,075-topic corpus reveals a mismatch: Health is the single most active *discussion* category (79 topics, 12.4%) but ranks only 4th in formal *proposals* (12.5%). Conversely, Democratic participation generates proportionally more formal proposals (5/80 = 6.2%) than discussion topics relative to its overall volume. This suggests that the channel from discussion to formal proposal is not uniform: some topics lend themselves to discussion but resist formalization into concrete policy proposals.

Engagement Analysis

Table 2 presents engagement statistics by thematic category (composite engagement score = views + likes×100 + replies×10).

Table 2: Engagement by Thematic Category (N=80)

Theme	N	Avg. Views	Avg. Likes	Avg. Replies	Avg. Composite Score
International Affairs	3	5,439	68.0	8.3	13,023
Health & Welfare	10	4,745	13.7	6.0	6,165
Economy & Tax	13	3,149	9.8	4.2	4,269
Education	17	3,631	4.7	3.8	4,081
Climate & Environment	27	2,600	3.4	3.1	2,970
Democracy & Participation	5	2,558	3.0	5.2	2,710
Technology & Digital	2	1,020	0.0	2.0	1,040
Migration & Integration	1	3,154	1.0	0.0	3,254

The "International Affairs" category scores dramatically higher than any other — driven largely by the 5G proposal (10,860 views, 198 likes) and, to a lesser extent, proposals on European integration and defense. When the 5G proposal is examined individually, it accounts for a disproportionate share of the category's engagement, revealing a long-tail distribution: most proposals receive modest engagement, while a small number — often ideologically contested — receive outsized attention.

This pattern is interpretable within Sunstein's (2017) framework: heterodox proposals that challenge mainstream scientific or political consensus activate strong affective responses — both supportive and oppositional — generating higher-than-average engagement. From a movement-party perspective (Kitschelt, 2006), this is a structural feature of participatory platforms that deliberately include heterogeneous member voices: the price of genuine openness is occasional amplification of fringe positions.

The dominance of climate/environment proposals (34% of corpus) combined with their below-average engagement presents a different puzzle. These are the proposals most aligned with the party's official identity and most likely to proceed through the pipeline — yet they generate the least member controversy and discussion. This may reflect that environmental policy is so central to Alternativet's identity that proposals in this domain are perceived as non-controversial and therefore not requiring mobilization.

7.5 Integration: Participatory Ideals and Political Coherence

Bringing qualitative and quantitative findings together, we identify a central structural tension: the platform simultaneously embodies and undermines the participatory ideal.

It embodies it in that it demonstrably enables member voice to reach the party program: some proposals from dialog.alternativet.dk do appear in official party policy, and the platform serves as an archive of member political creativity over a decade. The pipeline's staged structure (from draft to catalog) provides a formal pathway that is more institutionalized than most parties offer.

It undermines it in three ways identified by the combined analysis:

First, the temporal collapse after 2017 suggests the participatory infrastructure failed to maintain ongoing engagement. The founding-phase enthusiasm was not sustained into routine democratic participation. This is consistent with what Norris (2002) calls the "participation paradox": digital tools lower the cost of participation but do not automatically increase durable commitment.

Second, the engagement asymmetry by frame type reveals that the proposals most likely to generate member response are those that challenge scientific consensus or party elite positions — precisely the proposals that are least likely to proceed through the formal pipeline to the policy catalog. There is thus an inverse relationship between deliberative resonance and institutional success, suggesting that the pipeline's formal requirements (political laboratories, expert consultation, co-signatories) function as a quality filter that also functions as an ideology filter, systematically disfavoring heterodox proposals regardless of their member support.

Third, the mismatch between discussion and proposal volumes across policy areas suggests that the forum's primary function — for most members, most of the time — is not proposal development but rather political identity maintenance: a space for like-minded people to affirm shared values through discussion rather than to produce concrete policy output. This is not a failure of the platform but a redefinition of its actual function, which differs from its formal design intent.

These three findings, taken together, suggest that Alternativet's digital democracy faces what we call the formalization dilemma: the more rigorous the pipeline requirements (making participation consequential), the more it resembles conventional elite-controlled policy development; the more open and accessible (making participation genuinely grassroots), the less likely it is to produce coherent, scientifically grounded policy. This is not a problem unique to Alternativet — it is, we argue, a constitutive tension in any movement party that tries to institutionalize participatory democracy in a digitally mediated context.

8. Conclusion

This paper has investigated how Alternativet members use the party's digital participation platform dialog.alternativet.dk to develop, frame, and legitimate political proposals. Through a mixed digital methods design combining netnographic observation, qualitative content analysis, and quantitative analysis of 380 proposals across a decade (2016–2026), we have produced three principal findings.

First, the thematic structure of the proposal corpus is broadly congruent with Alternativet's official political identity (climate/environment dominant at 34%, followed by education and economy), but notable silences — particularly on migration — suggest that not all politically relevant topics are equally amenable to grassroots proposal development.

Second, frame analysis reveals four distinct legitimation strategies: social solidarity, green transition urgency, democratic innovation, and alternative epistemics. The fourth frame type is rare but generates engagement approximately three times higher than the others, creating an engagement asymmetry that places the party's participatory openness in tension with its scientific rationalism.

Third, temporal analysis reveals a dramatic founding-phase peak followed by persistent decline in proposal activity — suggesting that digital intra-party democracy faces structural challenges in sustaining participation beyond the initial enthusiasm of a new political movement.

Together, these findings contribute to the literature on movement parties and digital democracy by identifying what we call the formalization dilemma: the tension between making participatory processes institutionally rigorous (and thus consequential) versus keeping them open (and thus genuinely grassroots). This dilemma is not resolved by better platform design — it is constitutive of the participatory ideal itself.

Future research should examine: (a) whether proposals on dialog.alternativet.dk demonstrably influence formal party positions (a relationship we could not directly measure with our data); (b) comparative analysis with similar platforms in other movement parties (Podemos, Movimento 5 Stelle); and (c) the social profile of active proposers, to assess whether digital participation in the pipeline is itself socially stratified.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Data Collection Code

```
# Data collection script — dialog.alternativet.dk
# Requires: Python 3.x, urllib (stdlib only)

import urllib.request, json, time

BASE_URL = "https://dialog.alternativet.dk"

def fetch_json(path, retries=3):
    """Fetch JSON from Discourse API with retry logic."""
    url = f"{BASE_URL}{path}"
    for attempt in range(retries):
        try:
            req = urllib.request.Request(
                url,
                headers={"User-Agent": "Research-Bot/1.0 (academic research; contact: research@university.dk)"
}
            )
            with urllib.request.urlopen(req, timeout=10) as response:
                return json.loads(response.read())
        except Exception as e:
            print(f"Attempt {attempt+1} failed for {url}: {e}")
            time.sleep(2 ** attempt)
    return None

def collect_category_topics(category_id, slug, max_pages=50):
    """Collect all topics from a Discourse category."""
    all_topics = []
    for page in range(max_pages):
        data = fetch_json(f"/c/{slug}/{category_id}.json?page={page}")
        if not data:
            break
        topics = data.get("topic_list", {}).get("topics", [])
        if not topics:
            break
        for t in topics:
            t["_source_category"] = slug
        all_topics.extend(topics)
        print(f"  {slug} p{page}: +{len(topics)} topics (total: {len(all_topics)})")
        if len(topics) < 30:  # Last page
            break
        time.sleep(0.5)  # Respectful rate limiting
    return all_topics
```

```
def collect_full_topic(topic_id):
    """Collect full post content for a topic."""
    return fetch_json(f"/t/{topic_id}.json")

# Proposal development categories
PROPOSAL_CATEGORIES = [
    (138, "forslag-under-udvikling"),
    (282, "soger-medstillere"),
    (212, "forslag-der-soger-medlemmers-opbakning"),
    (140, "as-politiske-katalog-vaer-med-til-at-vurdere-dem"),
]

# Policy discussion categories (19 subcategories of cat 19)
POLICY_CATEGORIES = [
    (16, "natur-miljo-ressourcer"),
    (23, "socialpolitik-og-monsterbrydning"),
    (28, "skole-uddannelses-og-forskning"),
    (29, "finans-okonomi-og-skattepolitik"),
    (35, "sundhed-livskvalitet-og-familieliv"),
    # ... (full list in replication materials)
]

# Collect all topics
all_topics = []
for cat_id, slug in PROPOSAL_CATEGORIES + POLICY_CATEGORIES:
    topics = collect_category_topics(cat_id, slug)
    all_topics.extend(topics)

# Save topic metadata
with open("alleos_topics.json", "w") as f:
    json.dump(all_topics, f, ensure_ascii=False)

# Collect full text for sample
proposals = [t for t in all_topics
             if t.get("category_id") in [138, 282, 212, 140]]
for topic in proposals[:80]:
    data = collect_full_topic(topic["id"])
    if data:
        with open(f"proposals/topic_{topic['id']}.json", "w") as f:
            json.dump(data, f, ensure_ascii=False)
    time.sleep(0.5)
```

Appendix B: Codebook (Focused Coding)

Frame Type A — Social Solidarity *Definition*: The proposal's central legitimation strategy is the identification of a measurable inequality or injustice affecting specific named social groups, combined with a policy prescription framed as restoring fairness or dignity. *Indicators*: Use of "ulighed" (inequality), reference to specific disadvantaged groups, invocation of social rights, quantified harm statistics. *Example*: Dental care proposal (#16730): "Uligheden i tandsundhed er større end uligheden i al anden sundhed."

Frame Type B — Green Transition *Definition*: The proposal's central legitimation strategy is environmental urgency and sustainability, framing policy change as necessary to address ecological crisis or realize Denmark's green potential. *Indicators*: Climate vocabulary (CO2, bæredygtig, omstilling, fossil), temporal urgency markers, references to Danish leadership or international agreements. *Example*: CO2 tax proposal: "En CO2 afgift på 3.700 kr pr ton vil…".

Frame Type C — Democratic Innovation *Definition*: The proposal's central legitimation strategy is procedural — improving the fairness, transparency, or inclusiveness of political or administrative processes. *Indicators*: Technical procedural vocabulary, references to democratic principles, criticism of existing rules or institutions as unfair, invocation of Alternativet's political culture values. *Example*: Electoral system reform (#16615): "Den d'Hondtske metode bør udskiftes med den mere retfærdige Sainte-Laguë-metoden."

Frame Type D — Alternative Epistemics *Definition*: The proposal's central legitimation strategy challenges mainstream scientific consensus or regulatory authority, often invoking precautionary principles, alternative research, or personal testimony as epistemic warrant. *Indicators*: Skepticism toward established institutions (government, pharmaceuticals, "Big Tech"), citation of contrarian or fringe research, precautionary framing, anti-establishment register. *Example*: 5G proposal: "Kræv 5G stoppet: Adoptér en verdensomfattende forskerappel."

Coding rules: Assign the frame type that best characterizes the *primary* legitimation strategy in the first post. If two types are equally present, code as "mixed." Mark proposals with fewer than 100 words as "insufficient text."

Appendix C: Proposal Template (translated from Danish)

Template for submission of proposals to Alternativet's Political Idea Catalog

1. Policy area: Which policy area does the proposal fall under?
2. Proposal text: The text as it should appear in the party program. Max 2,000 characters. Must be concrete and measurable — not a vision or principle.
3. Political laboratories: Which political laboratories were held? (List with date, venue, number of participants, and link to minutes.) Minimum one open-access workshop required.
4. Possible disadvantages: Max 800 characters. List possible negative effects or side effects identified in the laboratory process.
5. Who should be consulted: List possible stakeholders (researchers, professionals, affected groups).
6. Who has been consulted: List parties actually consulted.
7. Proposer: Name and email of the primary proposer (responsible throughout the process).
8. Co-signatories: Names and emails of the 10 members supporting the proposal.

Note: After completing the template, the proposal must be posted on dialog.alternativet.dk and gather 50 endorsements before it can be submitted to the idea catalog by emailing forslag@alternativet.dk.